fancying themselves as the new Imran Khans, thinking that the whole team clicked on their efforts alone. They thought they were born leaders, but were far from it.

A true leader always takes his team along on his journey. A true leader is one who, even in a crisis, stands up first and comes forward before the others are held accountable and assures the team: 'I'm here, I'll take care of everything.' That's what makes him good. He is the guy who steps up to bat, to bowl and to face the fire.

As skipper or even otherwise, a habit that I'm proud of is that I spent more time with my juniors than my seniors. With the latter, I had a different approach. The night before a big game, I used to take my seniors out for dinner, ask them for advice, understand their approach, gain their confidence and just generally be on the same page in terms of strategy and tactics. With the juniors, however, I used to hit the beach, play football, head out for a meal or plan a relaxed evening. That was how my leaders, greats like Wasim Akram, had groomed me. Sadly, that wasn't how some of these other 'wannabe Imran Khans' worked. If you want to be a dictator, you should command an army, not a cricket team. That's my advice to any aspiring cricket captain.

My intention of being close to the juniors was to stay aware of their issues and understand what was on their mind. It helped me know them intimately and have a better pulse on the team. This way, I could help them, even if the issues they faced were to be tabled in front of the PCB. Being close to the guys – that was my style. Today, by the grace of God, I can seriously challenge anyone: ask any member of the Pakistan team who has played with me over the last few years and they will tell you that their best times have been under my captaincy. Our winning statistics may be a different story altogether – I'm talking about honesty, discipline and team morale.

There have been some who have criticized me for having a 'relaxed attitude' towards the boys when leading them. Fair enough – I never stopped any of them from partying and enjoying themselves. They're young sportsmen, after all. I understand their point of view and their expectations. I would even consider hanging out with them, if possible. My only demand from the boys was this: even if you give me 10 per cent discipline off the field it's acceptable. But give me 110 per cent on the ground, where it matters most. Give me all the sweat and blood that you can produce when you're on the field. Give me that and you can do whatever you please before or after the match. The boys, during my brief tenure as captain, were reasonably happy with this arrangement and they delivered too.